A century later, the Chauhans of Ajmer took control of the city and substantially expanded it. Now renamed Qila Rai Pithora, this was the capital of Prithviraj Chauhan. I was pleasantly surprised to find that large sections of the walls of this city have survived, although almost no one visits them. Anyone interested can drive to the northern end of Mehrauli village and will find them just past Adam Khan's tomb. The approach is not pretty and is used as an open toilet by a nearby slum. The visitor is therefore advised to walk through one of the shanties and climb on top of the walls. The walk on top of the nine-hundred-year-old ramparts is beautiful. As one leaves the village behind, one is surrounded by a thick forest of thorny Kikar trees. The walls extend a couple of kilometres and along the way one can distinguish towers and other structures including a major gateway. Perhaps Prithviraj used this gate as he bade farewell to the beautiful Samyukta as he rode out to face Muhammad Ghori. The urban landscape of Delhi can just be discerned beyond the trees even as the Qutub Minar looks sternly on.

When the Turks captured Rai Pithora, they made it their Indian headquarters and began to remodel it for their own use. The Qutub Minar complex, a UNESCO World Heritage site, has some of the oldest Islamic buildings in northern India. At its centre is the mosque built by Ghori's slave-general Qutubuddin Aibak. An inscription on the east gate of the mosque tells us that it was built by demolishing twenty-seven Hindu–Jain temples. [17] Defaced idols can still be discerned amongst the columns. Interestingly, the Iron Pillar was allowed to continue standing on one side of the mosque courtyard. Perhaps it was an effort by the new rulers to appropriate ancient symbols of power. It is also possible that Qutubuddin wanted to let it stand in the shadow of his own great column, the 72.5m-high stone tower of the Qutub Minar, a medieval example of 'mine is bigger than yours'. It is a truly impressive structure even by modern standards. When the Moroccan traveller Ibn Batuta visited Delhi over a century later, he was impressed by both the spectacular height of the tower and the unique metallurgy of the pillar. [18] He also tells us of how a later sultan wanted to